problems—with ease. He was a genius who was never afraid of problems. Later in my life, when a rocket project either failed or got delayed, I thought of Prof. Kothandaraman and took the problem head on. But life is not always rocket science, as the spy case would teach me more than thirty years later. However, when the universe appeared to be conspiring against me, I conjured up images of my gurus, and when everyone said I may not be able to make it to sanity, I told myself: It's possible.

Because of the Chinese aggression of 1964, the course was accelerated to be completed in January 1965, a couple of months ahead of schedule. Before the course ended, I had started dreaming bigger. Royal Naval Engineering College in Southampton, UK, was offering a course in naval engineering; I applied. I also sent in my application to Princeton University and California Institute of Technology (Caltech). There was no reply from Southampton. With offers of admission from both Princeton and Caltech came a dilemma: My mother was ailing; do I chase my dream or be with her? Mother did not say anything, but I could sense what she wanted. 'Be near me,' appeared to be telling me. 'The nearer the better.'